the Afghan government, believing that the real reason behind its procrastination was its reluctance to face a definite break with Russia.[124] As the viceroy had noted, even if Soviet Russia did not attack Afghanistan militarily, pressure would undoubtedly increase on the emir should he sign an exclusive treaty, as the Bolsheviks would no doubt claim that he had sold out his country to Britain.[125] Whatever the reasons, by the end of July it had become clear that despite Dobbs' efforts 'there is now little hope of [the] Afghans accepting [an] exclusive treaty'.[126]

Reading began, instead, to advocate a pis aller ('last resort') agreement – a treaty which would prevent Bolshevik consulates being established near India's frontiers, but would not insist on Kabul making a complete break with Moscow. In return, Britain would still offer the emir munitions and a (albeit reduced) subsidy.[127] However, reluctant to lose the possibility of an exclusive treaty, on 5 August 1921 the Cabinet expressed its disapproval of Reading's suggestion, 'which, it was felt, conceded too much, obtained too little, and, if offered by Sir Henry Dobbs, would be the extreme limit of humiliation for the British Empire'.[128] During the meeting, attention was paid to 'well-informed' articles in the Manchester Guardian which indicated that the reluctance of Afghanistan to sign an exclusive treaty with Britain was less to do with fear of the Bolsheviks than with pan-Islamic pressure. In the Cabinet's opinion, therefore, the current Greek successes over Turkey would soon weaken the pan-Islamic movement and make the Afghan government more willing to sign an exclusive treaty.[129] That the Cabinet appeared more prepared to listen to a newspaper than the Indian government when it came to Afghanistan would be surprising were this any other Cabinet.

Nevertheless, when the Afghan government finally decided to ratify the Soviet treaty, in late August 1921, the issue of the exclusive treaty became a moot point.[130] The Home government now became willing to consider a pis aller agreement, but reverted back to the original proviso that the Afghans make full disclosure of their relations with Soviet Russia.[131] The disclosure of its dealings with Moscow was still a contentious matter with the Afghan government, however. Quite bluntly, the Afghan foreign secretary, Tarzi, refused Dobbs' demand to see the agreement, telling him instead that he